

Sufi Ruhaniat International Esoteric Studies Program



God is Breath
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Class 1

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Toward the One, the Perfection of Love, Harmony, and Beauty, the Only Being, United with All the Illuminated Souls Who Form the Embodiment of the Master, the Spirit of Guidance.

Ryazat: Esotericism Githa Series II

Number 1: Fikr

The breath is the current which is established between all planes of man's existence. Its current runs from the life unseen to the life on the surface, thus uniting spirit and matter both. When the breath leaves the material being of man, then comes what man calls death, which shows that breath is the sign of life and life itself; and its contact with the body keeps the body alive and its contact with the mind keeps the mind alive, but neither body nor mind are life. If there is any sign of life we can trace on the surface, it is no other than the breath.

Therefore, Sufis take the breath as the means of getting what they want from the life unseen to the life on the surface; also, they make it a means of sending what they wish from the life external to the life within. The breath may be considered as a lift that can take you to any floor up and any floor down. By the help of breath you can send your thought anywhere and to any plane and bring about desired results. In breath abides all the mystery there is. The Sufis' object being self-realization by the ideal of God, they work for its attainment by the means of the breath, which they call Fikr, and an ideal so attained becomes their property, their kingdom, forever.

Number 2: Rhythm in Fikr

Rhythm is the nature of motion, and motion is the nature of life. Life is not possible without motion, and motion is not possible without rhythm. It is rhythmic motion which keeps the whole universe going, and the same motion is the hidden secret of our lives, as we are a miniature universe within ourselves. Our breath is both the cause and effect of this rhythmic motion.

Inhaling and exhaling is just like the pendulum of the clock. When it is regular the clock goes on regularly, when slow the clock goes slow, when quick the clock goes fast. So it is with us. When our breath is rhythmic, all things go well—the mechanism of our body, the working of our mind, and the work of our feelings, all are normal. Therefore, all we think, speak, and do is normal and right. When the rhythm of our breath is irregular, all illness comes, thoughts wander, feelings are upset, and our life becomes full of confusion. All we feel, speak, and do has a bad effect, in other words, a wrong effect upon ourselves and others.

Therefore, by Fikr the Sufi sets their breath to the proper rhythm; and when it becomes a habit by a practice done every day, the Sufi's whole life becomes orderly and regular, because the rhythm in time becomes a habit of the breath. And while awake or asleep, the breath goes on rhythmically, keeping all pulsations in rhythm, on which the health entirely depends. The rhythm so produced by the breath keeps the thoughts in order, the will powerful, the memory in order, the feelings normal—and thereby all one's affairs in life come into perfect and proper order.

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Asrar Ul Ansar: Mysticism Githa Series I

Number 6: Effect of Urouj and Nasoul in Grades

Inhaling is called Urouj, and exhaling is called Nasoul, and each has its particular part in the life of an individual. Breath is life, and its work is to take the condition from within to the external plane, and to take the conditions of the external plane into one's inner being. When one exhales, the condition of the inner plane is brought out, and when one inhales, the condition of the external plane is taken in. When exhaling, the harmony or inharmony of the soul is brought out, its influence first working on one's mind, then on the body, then on surroundings. When inhaling, the conditions of the external plane—harmony or inharmony—are drawn into the body, then into the mind, then into the soul, which sets the soul either in calmness or in disturbance. When exhaling, one's feelings and thoughts first work on one's body, then on surroundings. When inhaling, the thoughts and feelings from the external plane are drawn into the body and into the mind. The same is the case with the physical body; it sends out the gases with exhaling, and inhaling, takes in all the fine properties from one's surroundings.

Number 7: The Effect of Jelal, Jemal, and Kemal

The whole creation has been formed by the law of rhythm, and rhythm is the cause of all the variety we see in nature. The sun, moon, the stars, woman, man, and all other aspects of nature differ owing to the law of rhythm. Therefore, the seer understands all things and their past, present and future, by the rhythm of the breath. There are two peculiar forces in the rhythm, which in music are called strong and weak accents. Suppose we push the pendulum of a clock with the finger ... the first swing it will make will be strong, the next turn it will take will be the reaction of the first force, which naturally will be milder in force. So it is with the breath; the breath which flows through the right nostril is Jelal, which represents strength. The breath that flows through the left nostril is called Jemal, which is milder.

Breath being the very life, and its influence being not only on our mind but even on our life's affairs, the Jelal and Jemal count greatly with our life's affairs. And when the rhythm is broken, meaning upset, the Jelal and Jemal come into conflict with one another, that is called Kemal. During this time the strength with which the Jelal and Jemal hold our affairs is exhausted, and it brings failure and destruction. Therefore, the Sufi breaks himself to God, Who does not receive them who are unbroken. Uniting with God, the Unlimited, means breaking the self that is limited.

Number 8: Mysticism: Relating to Jelal

The Jelal aspect shows the strength and power of nature. We can find Jelal power flowing through the right nostril as breath; working through the right hand, giving it an inclination to move first; through the right foot, giving it an inclination to step first. In the senses, that which shows is Jelal, that which sees is Jemal. That which speaks is Jelal, that which hears is Jemal.

The same thing we find in our thought. The thought which rises of itself in the mind is the Jelal thought; the thought which is caused by some other source is the Jemal thought.

Every person has either a Jelal temperament or a Jemal temperament. A person with temper is Jelal; with courage, is Jelal; with power, with strength is Jelal. A person with kindness, tolerance, forgiveness, meekness, mildness, modesty, humility, is of the Jemal temperament. Then, through the day and night, man changes his condition from Jelal to Jemal and from Jemal to Jelal, either owing to the influence of his breath or controlled by the breath of another, or a situation makes him be in Jelal or Jemal, or his own thought, speech, or action.

In war, the offensive is Jelal, the defensive is Jemal; in trade, the purchaser is Jelal, the seller is Jemal; on the stage, the performer is Jelal and the audience is Jemal. Jelal has a tendency to be active, and sometimes it acts beyond control. Therefore, in the capacity of Jelal, a greater control is needed than in Jemal, for everything that runs quickly is in danger of falling.

Among the Sufis, there are two kinds of adepts, Jelali and Jemali, and each has their own line of progress and action. They are not called so for their temperament but for their method of progress and action. The Jelali among them, with their great psychic power, can prophesy and cast out devils and heal, and control the world and heavens, according to their development. They are mostly among the dervishes, faqirs; and sometimes they are called rind, when they are under a guise which deludes the pious, keeping them from going near them. Jemali are the ones who are with God throughout the day and night, who love and repent, and bless and serve, and glorify the name of their Lord, and guide their followers through all difficulties in the spiritual path, and draw people to God from the struggles of life. Their way is that of the saints of the past.

Number 9: Jemal

Jemal is the balancing force of nature, which balances the power of Jelal. For instance, the sun is the Jelal force, and would burn the whole universe if there were not the moon to balance its heat. In Vedantic language, these two powers are termed Shiva and Shakti, the essence and nature. This can be seen in love and beauty, also; the former being Jelal, while the latter is Jemal. If it were not for the beauty, the love would have destroyed the whole being. There is a verse of Sharif: "It is my eyes in wrath that have created the lightning, stars, sun and moon. What upheaval there would be if a spark escaped from the fire of my heart!"

Jemal is the life force that in the breath flows through the left nostril, and during Jemal, all affairs of a gentle nature are well accomplished, as during the time of Jelal, works of a gross nature. The people who have the Jemal temperament show grace and beauty in their thought, speech, and action, and control and balance as well. The reason is that the life force is not in its great intensity in them. The people of Jelal temperament show the contrary. A person of Jemal temperament is easy to get on with, and a person of Jelal temperament is difficult. And yet, it depends upon the evolution of the person. The Sufi, understanding the nature of Jelal and Jemal, acts harmoniously in all situations of life.

Number 10: Relating to Kemal

Kemal is the culmination of Jelal and Jemal. Kemal comes when Jelal and Jemal meet, and in the meeting of Jelal and Jemal, there is naturally a conflict. The Kemal breath is that which flows through both nostrils. Every thing and object in this world is either Jelal or Jemal; no one

except God can be attributed with Kemal. All destructions are caused by Kemal, such as earthquakes, storms, floods, wars, death, and Qayamat, the end of the world.

The Jelal or Jemal temperament can be found in everybody, but the Kemal temperament is found only among the holy beings who are living dead, who live in God, not in themselves. Every action, when it reaches Kemal, ceases to exist, and every person and every plane of being, after reaching Kemal, has a fall back. Therefore, those who study the nature of life and who value the unchanging nature of life, drink the bowl of Kemal, however bitter it may appear for the time. This is the bowl of poison that Mahadeva drank, this is the cross on which Christ was crucified.

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Excerpts from Githas on *Dhyana*: Meditation

by Murshid Samuel L. Lewis

note: emphasis by Wali Ali

The first thing that is necessary in meditation is to realize it is an act of attunement, an **attunement with God**. Therefore while it is necessary to relax, while it is important to control the emotions and the functions of mind and body, it is also important to raise, so to speak, **the pitch of the heart**, so that this attunement can be accomplished. [*Series I, Number 1 (A)*]

Sympathy means an attunement, a feeling with, but there is a negative way and a positive way of sympathizing. In the negative way one feels the suffering, the pathos, the pain, and unites in grief but does not bring much help. In the positive way, one raises the other from sorrow; one is able to give them their better condition without taking on the lower condition. This is true healing. That is the reason why one must repeat “Towards the One” so much during the healing service, and gradually attune oneself to the Divine rays which are health-giving.

But this is not only so in healing, but in all forms of inspiration, in poetry, music, art, invention, and all aspects of the creative process. The more one meditates the more one rises to the essence of things, becoming a vehicle for divine expression. There every aspect of life becomes an art and a science.

One going to his meditation feeling, “God is my Teacher, I have something to learn, I will listen attentively,” will be rewarded with the greatest blessing, receiving in the Silence and Meditation that which they are capable of understanding, and by this gradually their purpose of life will be unfolded. [*Series I, Number 4 (A)*]

When the breath is kept in rhythm and is refined, **the magnetism**, which is ordinarily consumed in the activities of mind and body is preserved. [*Series I, Number 2*]

There should be a balance between meditation and activity. If this is continued one will find his **meditation even in his everyday life**. [*Series I, Number 5*]

One can never meditate too much. This does not mean going into one’s closet, but it means keeping the heart fixed on God, to keep the mind fixed on the invocation, every moment day and night, so the very breath will keep on calling, “Towards the One.” Then the hour will arrive some time when the Talib will realize their true being. And what is that true being? It is God, the Only Being. [*Series I, Number 5 (A)*]

Meditation is the task of escaping from the control of the lower mind and living in the heart. It is only when the consciousness is in the heart that the soul can be free. By “heart” is meant not only physical heart but all that is physical that is connected with the heart, and at the same time it includes all the higher emotions, purer thoughts and deep intuitions. All these belong to the heart....

One of the main purposes of meditation is the control of thought so that the mind will be illuminated by this life and light from within. Spiritual practices that purify the breath make it possible for the breath also to be used as a vehicle of the soul.... In meditations, especially according to the Sufi methods, no direct attention needs to be paid to the breath, yet the more the breath is purified, the easier it is for the heart to illuminate the mind.

One physical aspect of this is that the whole being is in rhythm in meditation. The body is at rest, the flow of the breath and blood is rhythmical, the mind vibrations become quiet, and gradually through long practice, all the functions of the mind such as thought, reason, memory, I-ness, become dormant. Sitting at ease or in posture, holding a divine thought, the heart gradually controls the mind and the inner light becomes visible, so to speak, before the naked eye. [*Series III, number 1*]

Pure meditation aids one to reach into the inner recesses of the heart. Concentration is principally concerned with mind, whereas meditation, while not entirely unconcerned with mind, centers the soul where it belongs: in the heart.

So if there is any form of concentration to be used in meditation, it consists in first getting into the rhythm of the heart, even though it be done by watching the heartbeats, feeling them and harmonizing with them. Then one centers all feeling in the physical heart and out of feeling selects love, and out of love, Divine Love. So meditation may be said to begin with a great sweep at the outside of a circle, getting further and further within that circle until one reaches the center of the circle, and at the same time that very centralizing of attention draws to one all that God has, for to him that gives all to God, Allah bestows whatever is his need. [*Series III, number 3*]

Sufism is not a code of rules; the purpose of Sufism is to bring souls to God realization. Allah is beyond all Attributes and Qualities, being All Essence. Understanding this, every breath can become a meditation wherein one puts full dependence upon Allah and there will be no moment which will not be a meditation, no moment of separateness from God. [*Series II, number 3(A)*]

It is not necessary to consciously strive to alter the breath rhythms, but the steady repetition of those spiritual exercises which have been given to one by the teacher helps more than anything else on the path toward God. [*Series II, number 6(A)*]

Yet there is always need to enter into the silence above sound, and find the peace which is all-inclusive....As a person enters the silence, so does the silence enter into him or her. As one unites with the universe, so does the universe manifest in them. This is true, no matter what be

one's path or training. Ultimately one arrives at this destination. But **this is the silence of all-life, which without containing anything may be said to contain all-things. Therefore one is said to enter the world-egg or worldwomb.** This accounts for the teaching of the Mother of the World, the Divine Mother, the Bodhisattva Avalokitesvara or Kwan-yin. It represents the stage of realization of union with the silence, and as all may so unite, all are said to have a common mother. The silence of the womb and the silence of Universal Sound are each used to symbolize the other. [*Series II, number 7*]

This means that the true life is in God, the Only Being, and through God-realization each one finds their true self. Initiation is the beginning and perfection is the end, the making complete. But where is the beginning and where is the end? They are both in Silence, in God. In the Silence we were born and to it we return....

Therefore the perfection of meditation is meditation. It is the perfected souls who continue ever in meditation, being absorbed in meditation, creating from their meditation and living in that meditation. The spiritual life is the drawing of sustenance through the breath from God. It is a life of praise, yet of sobriety and balance, a life of fullness and emptiness both, being empty of self and filled with God. This is the true purpose of initiation and spiritual training from the moment the mureed takes Bayat until the Eternity of Eternities, Time without Ending. [*Series II, number 10(A)*]

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**Excerpt from Gathas on *Pasi Anfas*: Breath
Series III, Number 1**

Commentary by Murshid Samuel L. Lewis

In the Sufic walks abdomen centering, heart or chest centering, and head centering are all used. One learns about them through practice and exercise. One does not learn much about them through theorizing and discussing. Yet as the science and art of walking and then dancing, are developed each devotee finds within themselves something of which they may not have been aware.